

MICHAEL KENNEDY

UX RESEARCH & DESIGN LEADER: CROSS-FUNCTIONAL PROJECT DELIVERY & DATA-DRIVEN INSIGHTS

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I'm a Principal-level UX Researcher with 14+ years building and running research practices, setting the standards and methodology that guide how an organization does research and turning findings into decisions that actually change product direction. I started my career as a hands-on designer, and that background still shows up in how I work: I'll prototype something myself when it helps make a point, and I care as much about design quality as I do about the research behind it. When a question calls for real statistics rather than a gut read, I run the analysis myself in R or SPSS. I've also built AI-enabled research infrastructure with Claude and NotebookLM, queryable repositories and faster synthesis, that speeds things up without cutting corners. I coordinate cross-functional and senior stakeholders to keep initiatives on track from scoping through delivery, often in Agile/Scrum environments, and I mentor researchers to raise the bar for the function. I've spent most of my career working remotely, and I'm self-directed and effective there.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

UX Research Lead

DCG Worldwide

Feb 2026 – May 2026

Remote and On Location

- Owned the research strategy for a new paper billing process at a multi-service regional utility, covering screener design, a mixed-methods study plan, an AI capture process, and reporting format. The work traced what was driving billing-related call volume, repeat contacts, and escalations.
- Built a structured, AI-queryable research repository indexing 50 interviews in NotebookLM, enabling continued insight extraction for the client after the engagement ended. Clarified ambiguous statements in the audio in real time during sessions to strengthen the data feeding that capture process.
- Delivered findings across virtual and in-person testing, building rapport and maintaining neutrality with customers justifiably frustrated by significant billing errors, that reduced paper-bill comprehension call times and increased first-bill customer confidence despite a low-trust starting point.

Senior UX Researcher II

SimSpace

May 2024 – Dec 2025

Boston, MA (Remote)

- Built a new UX research practice for four product teams building a cyber range platform: a repository, personas, and standardized protocols that became their shared operating infrastructure.
- Designed customer feedback programs to shape and prioritize product roadmaps across four teams: an ongoing Design Partner Program, and the 2024 Customer Advisory Board, planned and prepared to open a new line of strategic customer input.
- Developed AI-enabled synthesis protocols using Claude, NotebookLM, and GPT that accelerated aggregation of interview and testing data into actionable findings.
- Validated every facet of a major milestone release through iterative testing to retain the company's top contracted DOD customer.

Lead UX Researcher

RCG Global Services

Oct 2023 – May 2024

Iselin, NJ (Remote)

- Led discovery research and multi-day design thinking workshops across five user groups (HR, Finance, Technical Staff, Product Management, and MEL) for a USAID-funded financial reporting platform supporting international development projects abroad, where reporting accuracy tied directly to congressional funding. Findings were reframed as "how might we" statements that directly shaped a platform redesign eliminating the pain points surfaced.
- Created a formal process for the working group's research intake, collaborative synthesis, and decision-making, and built reusable artifacts the design team continued using after the engagement ended.

Leadership & Management Development

Nielsen Norman Group, Eager Labs

Jan 2023 – Oct 2023

Watertown, MA (Remote)

- Completed a UX Certificate with specialty recognition in UX Management, concentrating coursework in Being a UX Leader, Workshop Facilitation, Research Operations, Design Systems, and Building Better Outcomes Between Product and UX, a deliberate focus on leadership and management capability.
- Completed Eager Labs' "Emerging Leaders" program upon executive referral, a five-session course for internal leaders being considered for people management, with a 360 feedback assessment and ongoing 1:1 coaching.

Senior UX Researcher

SecurityScorecard Inc.

Oct 2021 – Jan 2023

New York, NY (Remote)

- Drove 5–15% improvement in customer retention and conversion through end-to-end research on onboarding, pricing, and plan experiences with Growth product teams, shaping a persona-driven onboarding process the company shipped.
- Defined user archetypes for multi-jurisdictional security monitoring through extensive Jobs-to-be-Done and Jobs-Atlas research into regulatory and public-sector needs, informing a new tool the company delivered for public-sector monitoring.

Principal UX Researcher

Veracode

Mar 2020 – Oct 2021

Burlington, MA (Remote)

- Formalized a new UX Research practice as Veracode's first Principal Researcher, building research protocols, discovery frameworks, and design thinking capabilities from the ground up.
- Co-created a Developer Partner Program feeding discovery, concept testing, and usability testing with developer users, growing the participant base to scale research.
- Delivered 14 strategic research initiatives applying a Jobs-to-be-Done framework to drive product vision while mentoring researchers in research methodologies.

UX Designer / Researcher

IBM Resilient & IBM Security

Nov 2017 – Mar 2020

Cambridge, MA

- Led integrated UX design and research for IBM's first large-vendor incident response platform, Resilient, with experiences included in Cloud Pak for Security earning IBM "Leader" recognition from IDC and Forrester.
- Conducted participatory design research and rapid iterative testing, using structured artifacts (Sketch, Figma prototypes), Python-supported analysis for developer-centered interface design, and a formalized GitHub-based research workflow to inform product changes that enabled cybersecurity analysts to relate and reduce duplicate security incidents at scale.
- Formalized years of design thinking practice into IBM's official training, becoming a certified design thinking facilitator equipped to teach and mentor design thinkers.
- Designed a feature letting analysts cross-reference digital security incident artifacts directly, replacing a manual lookup process and cutting incident resolution time by roughly 10x.

Senior UX Researcher / UX Researcher

Constant Contact & Endurance International

Sep 2012 – Nov 2017

Waltham, MA

- Pioneered a site-visit research program grounded in academic rigor, shifting company culture towards radically centering the needs and expertise of the small business owner.
- Planned and ran a company-wide customer panel discussion for the entire organization, surfacing customer themes and concerns that shaped empathy and roadmap direction.
- Led initiatives end to end and executed 20+ studies annually using the widest methodology toolkit of my career: card sorting, tree-testing, first-click testing, statistical preference testing, quantitative testing in R, R Studio, Jamovi, and SPSS with ANOVA and t-tests, and an advisory role on a conjoint analysis.
- Mentored research interns and rotation program members, formalizing research planning processes that supported organizational growth.
- Maintained and evolved the research practice independently following the company's acquisition by Endurance International, leading the next phase of field research and conducting persona-defining studies with a participatory field research team of product stakeholders to co-create a strategic journey map across business units.
- Contributed to building out a fixed in-person usability lab with a one-way mirror and multi-camera capture system, creating an immersive environment for stakeholder attendance and lasting impressions of real insights by showing the cause of observed issues on video.

EDUCATION

Master of Science (MS), Human Factors in Information Design

2011 – 2013

Bentley University, Waltham, MA

Bachelor of Arts (BA), Visual & Media Arts

2005 – 2009

Emerson College, Boston, MA

CERTIFICATIONS

UX Certificate: Specialty Recognition in UX Management — Nielsen Norman Group, June 2023

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

Designing, Running, and Analyzing Experiments (Bayesian Statistics, R, SPSS) — UC San Diego, The Design Lab, 2017

Graphic Design Specialization — Cal. Institute of the Arts, 2017

Enterprise Design Thinking — IBM Security, 2017

Experience Mapping Workshop — Adaptive Path UXWeek, 2016

Gamification (Kevin Werbach) — University of Pennsylvania, 2014

AUTHOR & SPEAKER

Co-author of "You Want Me to What? A Practical Guide to Diary Studies" and Co-Presenter at UXPA International Conference, 2014

SKILLS

Research Methods: User Interviews, In-Depth Interviewing, Survey Design, Focus Groups, Usability Testing, A/B Testing, Contextual Inquiry / Ethnographic Research / Field Research, Heuristic Evaluation, Accessibility Testing (WCAG 2.1/Section 508), Concept Testing, Card Sorting / Tree Testing, RITE Methodology, Design Sprints, Longitudinal / Diary Studies, Competitive Analysis, Information Architecture, SUS / NPS Benchmarking, Participatory Design, Service Design, Journey Mapping / Experience Mapping, Persona Development, Jobs-to-be-Done (JTBD) Framework, Descriptive & Inferential Statistics (ANOVA, t-tests, Conjoint Analysis, Confidence Intervals/Adjusted Wald Method), Bayesian Statistics (Coursework), Qualitative & Quantitative Research, Mixed-Methods Research

Design, Practice & Project Leadership: Research Operations & Practice Building, Customer Feedback Program Design, Voice of Customer (VOC) Programs, AI-Enabled Research & Data Workflows (Claude, NotebookLM), Low / Medium / High-Fidelity Prototyping, Design Systems, Interaction Design, Visual & Graphic Design, Design Thinking Facilitation, End-to-End Project Ownership (Scoping, Timeline & Stakeholder Management), Agile/Scrum Environment Experience, Cross-Functional Collaboration, Process Design & Documentation, Executive & Senior Stakeholder Communication, Coaching & Mentoring, Facilitating Workshops, Product Discovery, User-Centered Design, Presenting Findings & Recommendations, Communication, UX Design, Product Design, Data & Analytics

TOOLS

UserTesting, UserZoom, UserLytics, Maze, Qualtrics, SurveyMonkey, Alchemer (Survizmo), Proven By Users, Ethnio, dscout, Dovetail, Great Question, Optimal Workshop, Respondent, UserInterviews, Pendo, Figma, Sketch, InVision, Miro, Mural, IBM Carbon Design System, GitHub, R / R Studio, Jamovi, SPSS, Python, Excel, Claude, NotebookLM